

D806

Secondary Disciplinary Literacy

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A ninth-grade biology teacher whose classroom was recently renovated with new lab benches notices that students can define light energy, chemical energy, and glucose. Yet they cannot explain this textbook sentence: The conversion of light energy into chemical energy results in the production of glucose. The class has 31 students. Which support best targets the difficulty?

- A.** Split the class into smaller groups so each group has fewer students.
- B.** Model how to unpack the sentence into clauses, such as: plants convert light energy into chemical energy, and they produce glucose.
- C.** Stop using the textbook and use only videos for science content.
- D.** Pre-teach definitions of the key vocabulary words before reading.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A student writes: Heat was added to the ice and then it melted and then the water turned into gas. The teacher wants the sentence to sound more like a scientist wrote it. Which revision moves toward scientific register?

- A.** The addition of heat caused melting, followed by evaporation.
- B.** Heat was added to the ice, and then it melted, and then the water turned into a gas, and that is evaporation.
- C.** The frozen, sparkling ice melted beautifully into shimmering water vapor.
- D.** I watched as the ice slowly melted and the water disappeared into the air.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

An eighth-grade history class is reading an 1850s newspaper editorial that praises a new railroad. The editorial was printed in the town where the railroad's main office was located. The teacher laminated the copies so they can be reused next year. Which question best builds contextualization?

- A.** What was happening in that town in the 1850s that might explain why this paper praised the railroad?
- B.** Why is it helpful to laminate primary sources?
- C.** How many paragraphs does the editorial have?
- D.** Do you think railroads are a good idea today?

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A student says a 1790s letter is useless because the writer uses words and ideas that sound unfair by today's standards. Which teacher response applies contextualization?

- A.** Agree and replace the letter with a modern summary of the period.
- B.** Ask what the letter shows about beliefs common in the 1790s and how that helps explain events of the period.
- C.** Have students count how often the writer uses unfamiliar words.
- D.** Tell students that older sources are always more reliable than newer ones.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

An Algebra I teacher who also coaches the debate team gives this problem: A phone plan costs \$20 a month plus \$0.10 for each text over 100. What does a month with 300 texts cost? Many students answer \$50 instead of \$40. The class meets right after lunch. What literacy move would help most?

- A.** Move the lesson to the morning when students are more alert.
- B.** Tell students math problems should be read quickly to save time for calculating.
- C.** Teach students to circle the numbers and find the keyword that tells the operation.
- D.** Have students reread slowly and restate each phrase, including for each and over 100, in their own words before solving.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

In a tenth-grade English class, a student writes about a short story: The story is about a boy who loses his dog and then finds it. I liked it because I have a dog too. The student's handwriting is neat and the paper is on time. What is the most important next step?

- A.** Ask the student to explain more about their own dog.
- B.** Ask the student to state a claim about what the story suggests and support it with a quoted line and an explanation.
- C.** Praise the neat handwriting and timeliness as evidence of strong analysis.
- D.** Ask the student to add more details about what happens in the story.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A seventh-grade science teacher notices that one student gives thoughtful spoken answers when the teacher reads the lab directions aloud. When the student reads the same directions silently, the student mispronounces words like photosynthesis and cannot follow the steps. The student plays in the school band. What is the most likely source of the difficulty?

- A. Time spent in band practice instead of reading.
- B. Language comprehension, so the student needs more background knowledge.
- C. A lack of interest in science.
- D. Word recognition, especially decoding multisyllable words.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

An eleventh grader reads a history passage aloud smoothly and accurately but cannot explain what it means, even when it is read to him. Which support fits best?

- A. Move the student to an easier class permanently.
- B. Phonics lessons on syllable patterns.
- C. More timed fluency practice until the student reads faster.
- D. Build background knowledge and academic vocabulary for the topic, and teach how the text is organized.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A chemistry teacher with fifteen years of experience reads a student's lab report. It opens with a hook question, uses first-person storytelling about the experiment, and ends with a personal reflection. The student earned an A in English last year. What is the best instructional response?

- A. Mark every grammar error so the student sees what to fix.
- B. Require a five-paragraph essay for all science writing.
- C. Show a model lab report and have students identify its sections and features before revising.
- D. Accept it, since strong English writing skills transfer to every subject.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

During a small-group discussion in a physics class, students debate whether a heavier ball falls faster. The room is noisy and every student speaks at least once. Most support their claims with phrases like I just think so or it makes sense. The groups are seated at round tables. What should the teacher do next?

- A.** Give sentence frames that require data, such as: Our measurements showed ____, so ____.
- B.** End the discussion and lecture the correct answer.
- C.** Ask students to share personal stories about falling objects.
- D.** Praise the discussion, since every student participated.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A world history teacher wants students to annotate primary sources for author, purpose, and audience. She hands out a colorful guide sheet that took two hours to design and tells students to begin annotating. Most students highlight random lines. What was missing?

- A.** More time for independent practice.
- B.** A quiz on the history content first.
- C.** Modeling with a think-aloud, then guided practice, before independent annotation.
- D.** A more detailed and colorful guide sheet.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

After a teacher models summarizing a science article and the class practices together, most students write accurate summaries with a partner. Which step comes next?

- A.** Assign a harder text with no support to all students.
- B.** Model the same summary again from the beginning.
- C.** Independent practice with a new article, with feedback.
- D.** Skip summarizing and move to a new unit.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer B Concept 1

A ninth-grade biology teacher ~~whose classroom was recently renovated with new lab benches~~ notices that students can define light energy, chemical energy, and glucose. Yet they cannot explain this textbook sentence: The conversion of light energy into chemical energy results in the production of glucose. ~~The class has 31 students.~~ Which support best targets the difficulty?

Target word: support for dense science syntax **Decides:** Students know each word; the trouble is processes packed into nouns.

A	Camouflage	Class size does not decide how to read the sentence.
B	Correct	Unpacking nominalizations turns packed nouns back into actions and actors.
C	Absolute language	Students need to learn to read science text, not avoid it.
D	Adjacent category	Vocabulary is already known; the barrier is sentence structure.

2. Answer A Concept 1 • transfer

A student writes: Heat was added to the ice and then it melted and then the water turned into gas. The teacher wants the sentence to sound more like a scientist wrote it. Which revision moves toward scientific register?

Target word: produce, not read, a nominalized sentence **Decides:** Scientific register condenses processes into nouns linked by cause.

A	Correct	Processes become nouns (addition, melting, evaporation) joined by a causal verb.
B	Dropped element	Adds a term but keeps the chained everyday structure.
C	Confusion set	Descriptive literary language, not scientific precision.
D	Inverted operation	Moves toward personal narrative, the opposite of scientific register.

3. Answer A Concept 2

An eighth-grade history class is reading an 1850s newspaper editorial that praises a new railroad. The editorial was printed in the town where the railroad's main office was located. ~~The teacher laminated the copies so they can be reused next year.~~ Which question best builds contextualization?

Target word: question that builds contextualization **Decides:** Contextualization asks what conditions of the time and place shaped the document.

A	Correct	Places the document in its time and place before judging it.
B	Camouflage	Responds to the classroom detail, not the document.
C	Adjacent category	A text-feature question, not a historical-thinking one.
D	Inverted operation	Pulls the reader into the present, which is presentism.

4. Answer B Concept 2 • transfer

A student says a 1790s letter is useless because the writer uses words and ideas that sound unfair by today's standards. Which teacher response applies contextualization?

Target word: correct a presentist reading **Decides:** The letter is evidence about its own time, read in that context.

A	Dropped element	Drops the primary source instead of reading it in context.
B	Correct	Treats the source as evidence of its era, not a modern opinion piece.
C	Adjacent category	A vocabulary task, not historical reasoning.
D	Absolute language	Age alone never guarantees reliability.

5. Answer D Concept 3

An Algebra I teacher ~~who also coaches the debate team~~ gives this problem: A phone plan costs \$20 a month plus \$0.10 for each text over 100. What does a month with 300 texts cost? Many students answer \$50 instead of \$40. ~~The class meets right after lunch.~~ What literacy move would help most?

Target word: math reading support **Decides:** Students skipped the small phrase over 100, which changes the calculation.

A	Camouflage	Timing does not fix the reading error.
B	Absolute language	The opposite of how math text must be read.
C	Inverted operation	Keyword hunting is the habit causing the error.
D	Correct	Precision reading makes small words that change meaning visible: only 200 texts are charged, so $\$20 + \$20 = \$40$.

6. Answer B Concept 4

In a tenth-grade English class, a student writes about a short story: The story is about a boy who loses his dog and then finds it. I liked it because I have a dog too. ~~The student's handwriting is neat and the paper is on time.~~ What is the most important next step?

Target word: move from summary to analysis **Decides:** The response summarizes and reacts; it makes no claim supported by evidence.

A	Adjacent category	Expands personal connection, not textual analysis.
B	Correct	Claim plus evidence plus analysis is literary interpretation.
C	Camouflage	Presentation does not show analysis.
D	Dropped element	More plot is still summary; the claim is missing.

7. Answer D Concept 5

A seventh-grade science teacher notices that one student gives thoughtful spoken answers when the teacher reads the lab directions aloud. When the student reads the same directions silently, the student mispronounces words like photosynthesis and cannot follow the steps. ~~The student plays in the school band.~~ What is the most likely source of the difficulty?

Target word: which component of reading is weak **Decides:** Listening comprehension is strong; reading the words is not.

A	Camouflage	An irrelevant detail with no link to the pattern.
B	Inverted operation	Strong oral understanding shows language comprehension is intact.
C	Adjacent category	Motivation does not explain mispronouncing words.
D	Correct	Understanding when listening but not when reading points to decoding.

8. Answer D Concept 5 · transfer

An eleventh grader reads a history passage aloud smoothly and accurately but cannot explain what it means, even when it is read to him. Which support fits best?

Target word: support when decoding is strong **Decides:** Accurate reading with poor understanding, even when listening, points to language comprehension.

A	Absolute language	Avoids the skill gap instead of teaching it.
B	Inverted operation	Decoding is already accurate.
C	Confusion set	Fluency is already smooth; speed will not add meaning.
D	Correct	Targets language comprehension, the weak component.

9. Answer C Concept 6

A chemistry teacher ~~with fifteen years of experience~~ reads a student's lab report. It opens with a hook question, uses first-person storytelling about the experiment, and ends with a personal reflection. ~~The student earned an A in English last year.~~ What is the best instructional response?

Target word: teach the discipline's genre **Decides:** The writing follows a general essay style, not lab-report conventions.

A	Adjacent category	Conventions are not the problem; the genre is.
B	Confusion set	A generic structure, not the science genre.
C	Correct	Explicit teaching of genre conventions with a model.
D	Camouflage	Leans on the English grade; genre conventions differ by discipline.

10. Answer A Concept 7

During a small-group discussion in a physics class, students debate whether a heavier ball falls faster. ~~The room is noisy and every student speaks at least once.~~ Most support their claims with phrases like I just think so or it makes sense. ~~The groups are seated at round tables.~~ What should the teacher do next?

Target word: raise talk to disciplinary reasoning **Decides:** Claims rest on opinion rather than the discipline's evidence.

A	Correct	Science talk uses data as the warrant for claims.
B	Dropped element	Drops student reasoning instead of building it.
C	Adjacent category	Anecdote is not the evidence science accepts.
D	Camouflage	Participation counts do not make talk disciplinary.

11. Answer C Concept 8

A world history teacher wants students to annotate primary sources for author, purpose, and audience. She hands out a ~~colorful guide sheet that took two hours to design~~ and tells students to begin annotating. Most students highlight random lines. What was missing?

Target word: missing instructional step **Decides:** No modeling or guided practice before independent work.

A	Inverted operation	Adds more of the unsupported step.
B	Adjacent category	Tests content, not the annotation skill.
C	Correct	Explicit instruction moves from I do to we do to you do.
D	Camouflage	The sheet was not the problem; the missing modeling was.

12. Answer C Concept 8 · transfer

After a teacher models summarizing a science article and the class practices together, most students write accurate summaries with a partner. Which step comes next?

Target word: next phase in gradual release **Decides:** Modeling and guided practice are done.

A	Absolute language	Jumps past a supported release.
B	Inverted operation	Moves backward when students are ready to move forward.
C	Correct	The final phase is you do.
D	Dropped element	Leaves out independent practice.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	5	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	8	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	7	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	3	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	8	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Nominalization in science text	Science writing packs processes into nouns (evaporation, conversion), so readers must unpack them back into who-does-what clauses.	Assuming the problem is unknown vocabulary when students already know each word.	Students can define the terms but cannot explain the sentence.
2	Contextualization in history	A historical document is read against the time, place, and conditions in which it was produced before judging what it means.	Reading a past document as if it were written today, for today's readers.	A document's date or setting is doing the work in the question.
3	Precision reading in mathematics	Math text is read slowly and repeatedly, translating every symbol and small word (of, per, at least) into meaning.	Skimming a math problem for numbers and a keyword.	Students grab numbers and pick an operation from one keyword.
4	Evidence-based literary interpretation	A claim about theme or character must be supported by specific textual evidence and analysis of the author's craft.	Treating plot summary or personal reaction as analysis.	A response retells events or states an opinion without quoting and explaining.
5	Simple View of Reading at the secondary level	Reading comprehension depends on both word recognition and language comprehension; diagnose which is weak before choosing support.	Giving every struggling adolescent reader comprehension strategies, even when decoding is the gap.	An older student who understands text read aloud but not text read silently.
6	Disciplinary writing genres	Each discipline has its own genre conventions (lab report, historical argument, proof, literary analysis) that must be taught explicitly.	Assuming one generic five-paragraph structure works in every subject.	A student's writing is correct in general but wrong for the subject.
7	Disciplinary discussion norms	Speaking and listening in a discipline means reasoning with that field's warrants: data in science, sources in history, text in literature, logic in math.	Counting any participation as disciplinary talk.	Students talk a lot but support claims with opinion instead of the field's evidence.
8	Explicit, structured literacy instruction	New literacy skills are taught explicitly with modeling, guided practice, then independent practice (I do, we do, you do).	Assigning a strategy and expecting students to discover how to use it.	Students are told to use a skill that no one has modeled.

Course scope (public description): Secondary Disciplinary Literacy is a cutting-edge course designed for candidates seeking to enhance their literacy skills within specific secondary academic disciplines. The course examines the distinct literacy needs of various secondary content areas, focusing on how reading, writing, speaking, and listening function differently in each discipline. Candidates will explore specialized language structures and text features relevant to each field and develop strategies to help students master these complexities. The curriculum integrates the science of reading to support critical engagement with and production of disciplinary texts, while also incorporating technology and digital literacy to aid students in accessing and interpreting discipline-specific information. The course combines research-based evidence with practical,

structured literacy activities to equip educators with the skills necessary to improve student achievement and understanding across all subjects. This course is a required component in SCED programs and will be assessed through a performance assessment task for both undergraduate and graduate versions.